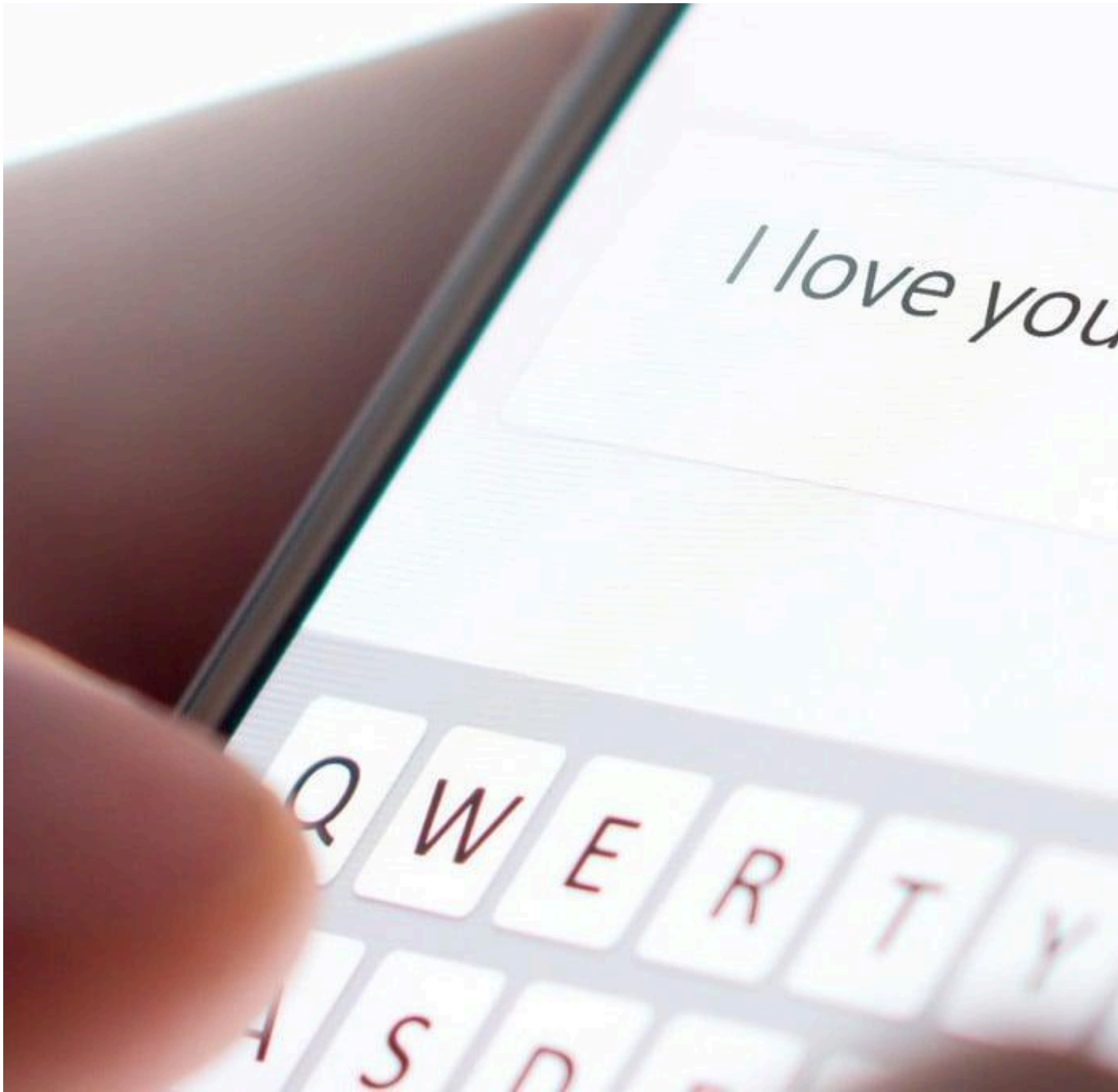


7-year love scam costs Malaysian woman nearly US\$500,000

The scammer, who the woman met on Facebook, posed as an American businessman working in Singapore, police said

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An accountant in [Malaysia](#) who thought she had met the love of her life through social media, engaging in an online “courtship” that lasted nearly seven years, had a rude awakening when she uncovered the painful truth: she had been scammed.

The 67-year-old woman lost more than 2 million ringgit (US\$485,000) in what authorities are calling one of the longest-running love scams on record. Ramli Mohamed Yoosuf, the director of Bukit Aman’s Commercial Crime Investigation Department, revealed details of the case at a press conference on Tuesday.

The saga began in October 2017 when the woman connected with the scammer on [Facebook](#). “According to the victim, the scammer introduced himself as an American businessman working in the medical equipment procurement field in [Singapore](#),” Ramli said.

After a month of online interaction, the two developed a closer bond and entered into a virtual relationship. Soon after, the man claimed he wanted to move to Malaysia but lacked the funds for travel. Eager to help, she made her first bank transfer of 5,000 ringgit (US\$1,200), a decision that would lead to a devastating cascade of requests.



The scammer only asked for 5,000 ringgit at first, but kept coming back for more. Photo: Shutterstock

The scammer continued to solicit money, fabricating excuses ranging from personal difficulties to business troubles. “In total, she had been duped into making 306 bank transfers into 50 different bank accounts,” Ramli explained, noting that the victim had borrowed money from friends and family to cover expenses that exceeded 2.21 million ringgit.

The reality of what had happened only hit her after she confided in a friend about her experience in November this year. Throughout the entire ordeal, she had never met her supposed lover in person or even through video calls. “The man would use all sorts of excuses. It was all only through voice calls,” Ramli said.

In a separate case, a 57-year-old woman fell victim to a similar scam, losing nearly 2.5 million ringgit. According to her police report filed on November 28, she had befriended a man on Facebook who claimed to be from England. He expressed a desire to visit her in Malaysia, but shortly after, she received a call from someone claiming to be a customs officer. This fake official informed her that her friend had been detained for carrying millions in US currency and demanded payment for various “authentication fees”, including an inexplicable certification from the Health Ministry. “In total, she made 13 bank transfers to 13 different bank accounts,” Ramli said.

In light of these distressing cases, Ramli urged the public to exercise caution when engaging with others online, particularly when financial matters are involved, highlighting the necessity of vigilance in an increasingly digital world where love can sometimes mask deception.

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